

Paul's Thorn and God's Sufficient Grace

Open to 2 Corinthians 12, Paul's thorn.

I have been assimilating and meditating. Understanding started going off in me probably five or six months ago that left the traditional views. Whenever I enter into a subject like this that I know He wants me to analyze, establish, and teach, the first thing I like to do is go back and find out what everybody else is saying about it.

Of course, Paul's thorn has always been a controversial subject, from who gave it to him to what it was. I have an excellent set of Greek books, and they have what they believe the Greek means. They will quote four or five different translations.

Because Paul wrote such a large letter with his hand, some say it was his eyes. Paul's thorn was his eyes. They were going bad. He could hardly see. So the "large letter" he wrote was large words, not a long letter like he usually wrote. He is like me. He gets it out, and they run.

Many of your finest Greek and Hebrew breakdowns, and these are their personal opinions, believe that. My favorite second one is that many believe it was epilepsy. Their reason is his encounter on the road to Damascus, how he fell down shaking on the ground. So they believe his thorn was epilepsy.

The third one, I think you will like this one too. For some reason, somebody came up with malaria of some kind that kept recurring and making him sick. Of course, because it was Paul's thorn that God gave him, He was not going to heal him. It was keeping him humble, see?

But let us begin in 2 Corinthians 12:1:

It is not expedient for me doubtless to glory. I will come to visions and revelations of the Lord.

He said, "Just for a moment, let me come to visions and revelations of the Lord."

I knew a man in Christ above fourteen years ago...

Of course, this is him.

...whether in the body, I cannot tell; or whether out of the body, I cannot tell: God knoweth...

They write like I do.

...such an one caught up to the third heaven.

And I knew such a man, (whether in the body, or out of the body, I cannot tell: God knoweth;)

How that he was caught up into paradise, and heard unspeakable words, which it is not lawful for a man to utter.

Of such an one will I glory: yet of myself I will not glory, but in mine infirmities.

Is this not interesting? He says, "I am not going to glory about all I saw in paradise. Rather, I am going to glory in my infirmities."

There was a great move about twenty years ago where one of the main teachings was that you were supposed to blatantly give God the glory. You had cancer, and you knew He gave it to you. You knew He allowed it, and it was His plan and was working some purpose in you. So you were supposed to glorify God for it. Not in it, for it.

There was a strong move like that. For some reason it played out. It did not last long, thank goodness. I had not been preaching very long, but I did not like it.

Paul said, "I will not glory in anything but my infirmities."

He goes on:

For though I would desire to glory, I shall not be a fool; for I will say the truth: but now I forbear...

Who would not want to glory? Have you been caught up into paradise lately? Any of you been to paradise lately? Paul said, "I would like to, but I forbear. If you are going to get any glory out of me, I will glory in my infirmities."

He says:

...lest any man should think of me above that which he seeth me to be, or that he heareth of me.

In other words, "Take a good look. This is me."

Now notice verse 7:

And lest I should be exalted above measure through the abundance of the revelations, there was given to me a thorn in the flesh...

It tells you where it comes from:

...the messenger of Satan to buffet me, lest I should be exalted above measure.

Notice why this thing came: "lest I should be exalted above measure through the abundance of the revelations." It came because of the abundance of his revelations.

Even in Mark 4, the sower sows the Word, and Satan comes immediately. What is he after? The Word. What do you think has changed?

Do you want to know why he came? Because of the abundance of Paul's revelations.

At this time, Paul was contending with the same group he contended with in 1 Corinthians, when men began to divide and think of themselves more highly than they ought. He said, "In this condition you are in, I am afraid someone will come preaching another Jesus, and you will go with him."

Why should I marvel at that? Satan himself has transformed himself as an angel of light, and his ministers as ministers of light, of truth.

When he said Satan transforms himself as an angel of light, tell me, he is not going to come preaching blatant darkness. He is going to come as God. Paul said, "Because of the abundance of my revelations, this thing has come."

He could not come to Paul like he was coming to the rest of them. I kind of feel insulted that he came to me as an angel of light. If they had not sung so well, I would not have listened to them.

What did they sing? They did not sing about darkness. A guy like me, who opens my Bible now and then, would not go for songs about dying and stuff. If Satan transforms himself as an angel of light, he is going to come as God. He does not come as himself. He picks the most vulnerable time to do it.

There have been a lot of people falling for this kind of thing. In 1 Corinthians, when Paul addressed these people, he said, "You ought not think of yourself higher than you should." When he finished addressing them, he put us all on an equal playing field. He said, "Why are you acting like this revelation that has been given to you originated with you? There is only one Teacher, and that is God, and you are all brethren."

He gets into a strong teaching: the first will be last, and the last will be first.

That kind of deception would not work on Paul. Paul was the one exposing it. Do you think that made the devil happy?

If Satan transforms himself as an angel of light, that means he comes as God. He does not come as himself. He picks the most vulnerable time to do it.

The devil knows. He knows we are not going to have revival. He knows in the Spirit we already have it. He already knows we are not going to leave the hospitals alone, and we are not going to leave any verse alone that says we can have what we say. We are not going to leave it alone until

we believe it. We are in for a ride.

But I can tell you this: you are going to be one happy camper when you get to glory. I am not going to leave it alone.

Here I was when the devil made his appearance. God was putting a new limb on my tree of what worship would do in the process of revealing the Father to you. I thought it was just about worship. No, it had a goal as an end.

You do not just worship to be worshiping, though we would do that anyway. Things happen. Worship was a major key to getting to know a side of the Father that I really needed to know in order to unlock certain revelations about Him, things He had been accused of doing for hundreds of years that He did not do.

Noah's ark and all that revelation we have taught on the early world, I needed an increase of His love in my nature to understand some of the things He had been doing that had no logic to me. You have to remember, He loved the Old Testament saints, but His fellowship with them was limited by their death nature. That did not mean He did not love them and make every provision, because He did.

Breaking into private worship, I was really vulnerable because I knew nothing about it. A Samaritan woman completely changed my life when Jesus walked up to her and told her about the water He could give her and how the true worshipers worship Him in spirit and in truth.

I always understood the "spirit" part because we changed natures and could finally give Him the fellowship He longed for. We could actually pour adoration and love for God out of a nature just like His. He longed for it. The Old Testament saints could not give it to Him. That is why John wrote about it: "He seeketh such to worship Him."

The true worshipers, He told the Samaritan woman, will worship Him in spirit and in truth, for that hour has now come. What He was telling her was, "I am going to die and be seated at the right hand of the Father. This is the hour for it. You are going to receive a new nature, and He seeks people with that nature to fellowship with Him as one of their own, which I am."

I knew about spirit, but I did not know what He meant by truth. I do now.

To worship Him in spirit is to fellowship with Him out of the same nature. To worship Him in truth means I now can do the things I could not do before.

Remember when the chicken taught the duck? The duck did not know he could fly for a long time because he was raised with chickens. One day he heard the truth, and he could understand all of it because a duck can teach a duck. A chicken cannot teach a duck. They have their own nature. It does not work.

The duck said, "My God, I can swim."

They said, "Watch what else you can do." He lifted off and flew.

So he flew south and met Lord Duck, Lord of all. He said, "I want to worship You, Lord Duck. I want to worship You in spirit and in truth."

He said, "You want to worship Me in truth, boy? This is the truth: you are a new duck creation. The truth is, you can fly. You want to worship Me in truth? Lift off."

I am a new creation. You want to know the truth? I can move mountains. I can get towns saved. I can fly.

I broke into private worship and got to know Him like I had not before. It was one of the last keys He had to put on before revival. I know that now. The devil knew he did not have much time.

Satan himself, and of course a messenger from him, his cohorts, came when I was about halfway into a fast. All of a sudden, I could hear this worship. It got louder and louder until I could hear it like you. I know how rock stars can write music now. If I could write music, I could have written that stuff.

They sang the old ones I knew:

Can't you hear the thunder rolling? Can't you hear the trumpets blow?

They had tenors. They had everything. There was a real bassy angel in that bunch. They were singing, and I was thinking, "Boy, I am so special. I can hear these guys out loud."

I was fasting and praying upstairs in our house. I came down and sat on the bed, and Rosalie was on the computer. They were singing that very song, "Can't you hear the trumpets sounding? Can't you hear the thunder rolling?" They were playing all kinds of things. I did not hear a harp anywhere in it.

I sat on the edge of the bed, and they were singing up a storm. They had followed me downstairs.

I said, "Rosalie, can you hear music and singing?"

She said, "Where?"

"In the room."

"What do you mean?"

"Can you hear them now?"

She said, "What are they singing?"

I stopped and gave her the exact words they were saying.

She said, "No."

I said, "Yes."

She said, "You can hear them?"

"Yes."

She said, "If I were you, I would not tell anybody."

So I did everything. I lay on the conduit, the air conditioning and heating system, to see if it was coming through there. I went into closets and closed the door, and I could hear them in there. Everywhere I went in the house, I could hear them. I went outside and could hear them fifteen or twenty feet away from the house.

One time they got so loud that the boys' music in the garage sounded like it was cranked up so high it was disturbing the neighbors. This time, for some reason, it was a gospel song. I thought, "Just because it is a gospel song, I still have to tell them they cannot run the whole neighborhood off."

I got out there, and the garage was locked. Nobody was in the backyard.

So what did I do? I danced out to church here and said, "I have my own angelic choir." Everybody said, "Yay, yay." Then I told them what happened, and they got quiet.

They did not sing to me anymore. Their next scheduled event was an appearance, and then I would finish selling you the goods. Then we would start seeing them. I saw them first, then would come the revival of sensationalism. Pretty soon we would move to Utah.

I have talked to some people, and they said, "Do you know how lucky you are to have survived that?"

The next scheduled time, I was fasting, locked myself up, and the third night they came. This time they got so loud that I started getting disoriented. It was like they were behind schedule, so they were putting the pressure on. I got so disoriented that I could not even find my way home from Sapulpa. They got louder and louder until it drove everything else out.

But praying in tongues, you know, there is a truth in you that will not leave you alone. Finally, I heard Him say, "You have a right to try the spirits." That is when I did.

These are the kinds of spirits Paul was addressing. He said, "You have reigned as kings without us, and I would to God ye did reign." One time he said the apostles were like the scum of the world, the offscouring of all things. In other words, the devil puts scouring powder on them and tries to rub them off the earth.

Paul was addressing those who reigned as kings, took your money, and filled all the things an apostle should not be, taking all the things an apostle should not take. You can understand why they got in the condition they were in.

My first encounter with devils was a hostile one. I had just finished a longer fast, and he came. The presence was so strong it was almost hypnotic. If I knew anything, I knew I was so wealthy I could not even spend all the money. But I also knew who it was.

I said, "You are not God, and I know you are not. Get out of here."

He did. God came, and He was just great.

The devil got so infuriated that he came back and said, "I am going to kill you."

I said, "If you could, I would already be dead. Get out of here, you liar."

Then he came back and said, "I am going to run everybody off." He got about two rows on the front. Watch that front row.

He did not spend much time then, but he took this deception road. This is the kind of operation Paul was talking about here.

So when Paul said, "Because of the abundance of my revelations, there has been given to me a messenger from Satan to buffet me," what he is saying is this: if you are not falling with that bunch, then he is going to come after you because you know the truth. Because of the abundance of Paul's revelations, this thing came.

If he came after Paul for that reason, then Paul was not being deceived. He was not going with the other bunch. He said, "Unless I get exalted like you guys are, there has been a messenger from hell camped on me. The reason he is there is because of the abundance of revelations that I have, and I am not going to go for that stuff."

You might as well know this: there are not too many apostles, as you would call them, who make it. Somewhere along the line, these things happen to them.

Look around. The office of a real apostle carries all the other callings in him. He is a devastating war machine. He can go from one village or one city to another and cause a tremendous revival with all the signs and wonders. He can establish the church, and if pastors were not trained before that, he can stay there until a pastor is trained, and an evangelist. He can train all of them to fill their offices because they all exist in him.

He is a devastating war machine, and the cost of it is his whole life. Do you understand? His whole life.

Paul said, "Lest I get exalted like you guys, I have been counted worthy to be stopped. He has come to stop me because that is what he does."

How Paul handled him is richer than a coal mine. My God, do you understand what you can find out about grace that will turn the greatest assault and power Satan has back?

When Paul went home, he said, "I am ready to be offered. They are not killing me. I am ready. I have fought a good fight. I have finished my course."

That is all we want you to say when you are done: "Yes, Jesus."

If you are really an apostle and full of that Word, backing it up with signs and wonders, the first ones are going to come after you. But so are the second ones. If the second ones come after you, it is because the first ones could not get you.

Hallelujah, Jesus. Tell me, are we going to have a revival? Why? Because we already have.

Paul said:

For though I would desire to glory, I shall not be a fool; for I will say the truth: but now I forbear...

In other words, "I am not going to be a fool. I will say the truth, but now I forbear, lest any man should think above me that which he sees me to be or hears of me. This is me. I am no special-call Hollywood kind of guy."

Then:

And lest I should be exalted above measure through the abundance of the revelations, there was given to me a thorn in the flesh...

Look, there is hell. There is a thorn in the flesh, a messenger from Satan. He has come to buffet me.

For this thing I besought the Lord thrice, that it might depart from me.
And he said unto me, My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness.

God was like a broken record, and I am glad He got through to Paul. He kept saying the same thing: "My grace is sufficient for you, for My strength is made perfect in weakness."

Paul's conclusion was:

Most gladly therefore will I rather glory in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me.

Instead of glorying in what he was glorying in before, he said, "I would rather glory in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me."

I once got a frantic phone call. "Brother Roberson, do you know your calling?"

I said, "I am glad I do not. I am glad I do not, but I do what I do."

Then some friends called and said, "Can you come to Chicago?"

I said, "Why?"

"Because there are some messed-up people up here."

I said, "I cannot really drop everything like that."

"Please."

I said, "Okay, I will go."

So I flew in, and they picked me up. Goodness, it was a convention of apostles and prophets. Some lowly pastors were there too, but they were nothing. They picked me up, and all the apostles were sitting around the table. Are you ready for this? It was in a house meeting, and there were special gold-rimmed cups we got to drink from. Even though it was somebody's house, they gave us a menu so we could order what we wanted. We were great.

The friends of the apostle who lived there said, "Here, you can order what you want." Gold-rimmed cups. I was just sitting there looking at this.

Finally the apostles focused on me. They said, "Who are you?"

I said, "Me? I have a church in Tulsa."

They said, "No, we mean who are you?"

I said, "I am a pastor."

They said, "Oh, okay."

As time went by, I attended their service that night, and they called me out. They basically told me I was backslidden.

The man who had the house had some authority, so he decided to change the order of the service. He announced to all the apostles that I would take the service the next night. I said, "You had better tell all the apostles first."

So they did, and the apostles said, "You are making the biggest mistake of your life." They immediately got their connections and did a thorough check on me. Do you know what I turned out to be? Just one of those faith guys from Tulsa. Nothing.

They said, "Nevertheless, he is still going to take the service."

The apostles said, "You are making a mistake."

"Nevertheless, he is still going to take it."

"Okay, we tried to warn you."

Boy, they all came out and sat on the front row. Now ask me if it bothered me. I have been there before.

I remember the message: "My glory I give unto you, that you may know that the Father loves you the same way He loves Me." Jesus said, "My glory I give to you so you can know the Father loves you with the same love He loves Me."

We found out what glory He was talking about by a few illustrated examples, like the duck.

One of those guys even had yellow shoes. I do not mean to be cruel, but He is not for this self thing. He is not for you gathering a bunch of people you are supposed to be serving, so they can serve you.

Nevertheless, about thirteen or fourteen minutes in, the power fell. Maybe a fourth of them fell between the chairs. Close to half were healed. Testimony after testimony after testimony. I tell you what, they did not know what to do.

When the service was over, I tried to be kind and hug them. Have you ever tried to open an ironing board? You grab it here and pull, and the bottom flies out, and you are trying to wrestle it open. There is nothing to hang on to. Man, they were so stiff it was like hugging an ironing board. I tried to pull them over to me, and their eyes were real big looking down at me. I was not going to hurt them.

Even though the meetings had two days left, they got on airplanes and went home.

By the time we get done with this story, I will not write it up exactly like I am talking, but Paul said, "I sought God three times." That was not all the same day. Each time he faced something worse than the last. God kept telling him the same thing: "You are going to fill the role of the real, and this thing is going to be there. So listen to Me. I can tell you where My strength lies."

That is what we are going to learn.

Hallelujah. I have had a great time.